deep-seated grievances and prejudices as regards our neighbours which unfortunately has repercussions on the followers of Islam in this country. You yourself have recognized this in your correspondence with the Pakistan Prime Minister. I have also laid stress on the fact that our secular ideals impose a responsibility on our Muslim citizens in India – a responsibility to remove the doubts and misgivings entertained by a large section of the people about their loyalty founded largely on their past association with the demand for Pakistan and the unfortunate activities of some of them. It is in this light that to my mind some tangible steps to deal with the present situation become urgent and that is why I have been insisting on a well-considered, firm and determined line of approach. I do not think that any discussion in the Working Committee or the AICC would be of any help. In fact, I am convinced that the less we discuss these matters in public or semi-public and the more we concentrate on setting a firm line of policy the better; it will avoid public bitterness and exhibition of tempers such as we are witnessing in Bengal and elsewhere today; it will also convince the people that we have a plan to deal with the problems and that we mean business. This would have a much more settling and steadying effect than a public discussion of the different lines of approach which are holding the field in the Press and on the platform. The need of the hour is to rally the country round a settled programme – settled not in the dust, turmoil and passion of public controversy but quietly in the meetings of a small business-like body as we did in the case of Punjab disturbances or Hyderabad. I am sure the country will follow us in a disciplined way once we have come to a decision in a clear-cut manner. I have no doubt things are going out of control in Bengal and may be more so there and elsewhere in India because of a feeling of frustration and the general belief that the Government has no fixed or final policy to deal with this grave situation.

You have also referred to the attitude which we have taken on communal hatred and violence. I do not think it would be correct to call it lenient. I think figures will bear out that we have controlled the communal Press far more drastically than the communist [press] and our action has been circumscribed only by the provisions of the law as interpreted by our legal